

# Bass

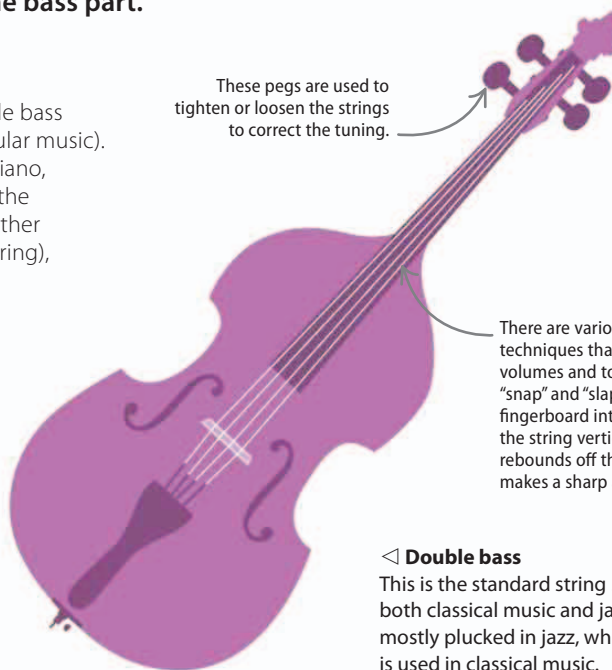
The bottom line of the harmony is called the bass. The ear is drawn to the top and bottom lines more easily than the parts in between. So the melody is commonly placed on the top line, and the harmony has its foundation in the bass part.

## Bass instruments

It is most common to hear the bass part on a double bass (in classical music and jazz) or a bass guitar (in popular music). However, the left hand of the keyboard, such as a piano, electric keyboard, organ, or harpsichord, also plays the bass part in any music with more than one voice. Other instruments that play the bass part include cello (string), bassoon (wind), and tuba (brass).

“As the **earth** is the **foundation** of the **other elements**, so the **bass** is the **foundation** of the **harmony**...”

Giuseffo Zarlino, 1558



These pegs are used to tighten or loosen the strings to correct the tuning.

There are various pizzicato techniques that produce different volumes and tone-qualities. Both “snap” and “slap” pizzicato bring the fingerboard into play, by plucking the string vertically so that it rebounds off the fingerboard and makes a sharp attack on the note.

### ◁ Double bass

This is the standard string bass for both classical music and jazz. It is mostly plucked in jazz, while a bow is used in classical music.

## Drone bass

The simplest type of bass is a drone bass, which sustains a single note over a long period. This restricts the harmony that can be placed above it, if the harmony isn't to sound random or too dissonant. Except for passing notes and suspensions, only those notes that sound consonant with the drone can be used for any length of time. The drone is either the tonic or the dominant of the key.

### ▽ Haydn, *Symphony No. 104*

This drone bass opens the finale of Haydn's last symphony. The opening is deliberately plain, with no harmony between melody and bass. This conveys a rustic effect.

**Finale. Spiritoso**

The important notes of the melody are the tonic D and the dominant A on which it begins.

The drone bass on the tonic D.

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